

DCAT-US 3.0 and federal statistics: the evidence behind each row

Companion to the brief of 8 October 2026. Brock Webb, U.S. Census Bureau.

How to use this file. The brief's table (section 3) gives one line per statistical need. This file gives the evidence behind each line, in the same order and numbered 1 to 8 as in the table. Each need answers the table's three questions in turn: did the Federal Committee on Statistical Methodology (FCSM) ask for it, where did it land in DCAT-US 3.0, and what do the international standards say. Each answer is a sentence drawn from the source cited after it, and the source numbers match the brief's source list. Where the source check could not confirm an answer, the file says so and gives none.

The result for each need uses the brief's labels:

- **Optional only:** it has a field in 3.0, but agencies may leave it out.
- **Recommended:** agencies are expected to fill it; it is not required.
- **Dropped:** it was in the 2025 working draft and is not in the published 3.0.
- **No field:** 3.0 has no field for it.
- **Different form:** the international standards (StatDCAT-AP, the European statistical version of DCAT, and W3C vocabularies) carry it differently from how FCSM asked for it.
- **Not confirmed / not checked:** the source check could not confirm that part.

1. series

Result: Dropped.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- FCSM's Framework for Data Quality asks that documentation state the expected periodicity of a data product's production and the time frames it covers. [8]
- FCSM notes OMB directives require agencies to publish annual release dates identifying reports as regular and recurring. [8]

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- The link marking a dataset as one release in a series was Optional in earlier drafts but no longer appears on the federal dataset page. [9][10][11]

What the international standards say

- Data Catalog Vocabulary version 3 makes series their own record type and links a dataset to its series with inSeries, which the current federal dataset page no longer lists. [9][10][2]

2. dimensions (breakdowns such as place, item, time)

Result: Different form; level not confirmed.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- The Federal Committee on Statistical Methodology's transparent reporting paper tells reporters to describe the data's categorical variables, called dimensions, such as place, item and time. [12]

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- Not confirmed by the source check.

What the international standards say

- StatDCAT-AP, a statistical catalog profile, and the Data Cube vocabulary name each breakdown as its own field in the record, not in a written description of variables. [12][13][14]

3. units of measure

Result: No field; FCSM ask not confirmed.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- Not confirmed by the source check.

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- Unit of measure is Optional, and it sits on the quality measurement class, giving the unit of a quality score rather than of the data itself. [15]

What the international standards say

- Not confirmed by the source check.

4. uncertainty (margins of error)

Result: Optional only.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- The Federal Committee on Statistical Methodology's report on transparent reporting for integrated data quality says sampling and nonsampling errors need to be measured and documented. [12]

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- DCAT-US 3.0 lists hasQualityMeasurement, a measurement of a dataset against one quality measure such as accuracy, as Optional. [9][10]

What the international standards say

- The World Wide Web Consortium's Data Quality Vocabulary expresses precision and accuracy as quality measurements, the same Optional property DCAT-US 3.0 adopts for quality reporting. [9][10][16]

5. methodology and provenance

Result: Optional, and different form.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- The Federal Committee on Statistical Methodology's framework for data quality and its transparent reporting report ask documentation to give source data and the methods used to combine it. [8][12]

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- Statements of a dataset's history, the activity that generated it, its source, and documentation links are each Optional on the dataset page. [9][10]

What the international standards say

- The World Wide Web Consortium asks for origin and history a computer can process automatically, while the statistical side asked for written detail on the processing methods used. [8][17]

6. revisions and versions

Result: Optional; form not checked.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- FCSM 19-01's transparent reporting report calls for errors to be measured and documented and for revisions to be regularly analyzed. [12]
- FCSM 25-03 on AI-ready federal statistical data asks agencies to return comprehensive metadata, including update timestamps, through their data product APIs. [18]

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- The Data Catalog Vocabulary profile for the United States, DCAT-US 3.0, marks version, versionNotes, hasVersion, hasCurrentVersion, previousVersion and replaces Optional on its Dataset page. [9][10]

What the international standards say

- Not confirmed by the source check.

7. quality dimensions

Result: Optional, and different form.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- The Federal Committee on Statistical Methodology's 2025 paper says each data element should be assessed for quality on named aspects, called dimensions, such as timeliness and accuracy. [18]

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- In DCAT-US 3.0 the Dataset element hasQualityMeasurement is Optional, and it lists quality measurements for the dataset such as completeness, accuracy, or timeliness. [9][10]

What the international standards say

- The Data Quality Vocabulary, a web standard, offers a quality dimension class but no fixed dimension list, leaving the choice to publishers, unlike the statistical framework's named set. [8][2][16]

8. restricted-access terms

Result: Recommended; form not checked.

Did FCSM ask for it?

- The CDO Council's data sharing report calls for establishing data use agreements that define how a party requests access to a dataset. [19]
- FCSM working paper 19-01 on transparent reporting adopts accessibility as reporting the conditions under which users obtain data, including where to go and how to order. [12]
- The FCSM data quality case studies report lists procedures and practices surrounding access, plus time from application to receipt, among the things to document for users. [20]
- FCSM's Framework for Data Quality describes special arrangements, such as Research Data Centers, by which users apply for access to restricted-use data. [8]
- The FCSM Framework for Data Quality states that confidential information compiled for official statistics should be used only for statistical purposes, a condition limiting dataset use. [8]

Where it landed in DCAT-US 3.0

- Separate structured fields for access limits, use limits and controlled unclassified information limits are Recommended, and the rights field is also Recommended. [9][10][1]

What the international standards say

- Not confirmed by the source check.

AI use in this document

Generative AI made a meaningful contribution. It located passages in the source documents, drafted the sentences in this file from them, checked each sentence against the passage it cites, and laid out this version from the author's direction. Sentences the check could not confirm were removed, not reworded, and repeated statements of the same finding were cut to one. The models were Anthropic's Claude Opus 5, Claude Opus 4.8, Claude Sonnet 5 and Claude Fable 5.1, used through Claude Code under a commercial subscription, 5 to 8 October 2026. The author reviewed and approved the content and is responsible for it. The passages themselves are quoted in the questions-and-answers attachment of 5 October 2026.

Sources (numbered as in the brief)

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